

SAFETY FIRST Police officers on patrol duty in Park Street, Kolkata

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the respondents said harassment of women in public spaces is a problem. What explains such dissonance between two southern neighbours with comparable socio-economic indices? Perhaps it is the silent weight of public vigilance and community enforcement in one state versus the shrugs and silences in another. But perhaps, too, it is the weight of perception—and perception, as every policymaker knows, can be as oppressive as reality.

Public transport—the lifeblood of urban India—emerges as a rare bright spot in the safety landscape. Eighty-six per cent of the respondents nationwide express feeling secure while using buses, metros and local trains. Maharashtra leads this category with 89 per cent of the respondents reporting feeling safe in public transit, a testament perhaps to Mumbai's generally well-regulated transportation network. Even Punjab, the laggard in this category, reports a respectable 73 per cent safety perception rate.

The survey's findings on traffic rule adherence present another fascinating window into India's relationship with civic order. Nationally, 54 per cent of the respondents claim that traffic rule violations are not regular in their areas—a statement that any visitor to India's cities might find surprising. Assam, often criticised for infrastructural inadequacies, ranks as the best-behaved state, with only 32 per cent reporting routine rule-breaking. Karnataka again finds itself at the bottom, with a staggering 89 per cent witnessing casual flouting of traffic norms. It seems chaos is less a function of development, and more an attitude problem.

In aggregate, 84 per cent of Indians say they would report a violent crime, 86 per cent feel safe in public transport, and 56 per cent feel secure in their neighbourhoods. On paper, these are respectable figures. But they mask the unevenness—the quiet tragedies and triumphs playing out in India's bylanes and alleys. Safety, after all, is not just the absence of danger, but the presence of trust. And trust, unlike GDP or growth rates, is not easily measured. It is sensed, it is lived, and it is lost in a moment.

This survey, for all its numerical precision, ultimately tells a story of contradictions and complexity. What it finds is that India's public safety landscape reflects its broader national character: uneven, evolving, and defying simple categorisation. ■

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